FREE GUIDE 04 · CAREER CONVERSATIONS

Passed Over. What Do You Ask Next?

Prepare a useful manager conversation about evidence, expectations and the next opportunity.

‘Keep doing what you’re doing’ gives you very little to act on.

A missed promotion can leave several questions tangled together: your readiness, the evidence people saw, and whether a role was available. A useful conversation separates them. The goal is clearer information and an agreed next step.

Start here

Write down the exact explanation you received. Beside it, write what you inferred. Mark each statement as known, assumed or still to ask. Do this before composing your reply.

01 Separate the facts

02 Ask for evidence

03 Agree a test

04 Set a review

Set aside 20 minutes. Work through the examples, then print page 4 for your own situation.

SEE IT IN PRACTICE

From a familiar response to a useful one.

Fictional examples for practice. Adapt the reasoning to the facts of your situation.

THE OPENING

Before: Why was I passed over when I delivered everything?

After: I want to understand the decision and make the next few months useful. Could we separate my readiness for the scope from the availability of a role? What did the decision makers need to see that they did not see this time?

You ask about the decision without assuming that delivery, readiness and role availability are the same question.

MAKE THE FEEDBACK OBSERVABLE

Before: They said I need to be more strategic.

After: Could we look at one recent situation where you wanted different judgment from me? In the regional rollout meeting, what would a stronger recommendation have included? What would have changed the decision?

A specific situation gives you something you can practice. A label alone can lead to months of guessing.

AGREE A NEXT TEST

Before: I will work harder and be ready next time.

After: I can lead the options review for the next rollout. Could we agree which decisions I own, what evidence would show stronger judgment, and who needs to see that work? Let us review it in six weeks. I understand that demonstrating readiness does not guarantee an open role.

A bounded assignment, visible evidence and a review date create a useful plan without pretending to control the promotion outcome.

THE METHOD

Five questions worth taking in.

1. What drove this decision?

Was the issue readiness, evidence, sponsorship, role availability or another constraint? Ask what your manager can share; do not request confidential comparisons with a colleague.

2. What specific example shows the gap?

Ask for a recent situation and the response expected at the next level. Repeat the example back to check you understood it.

3. What evidence would change the assessment?

Agree observable behavior and outcomes. ‘Be more visible’ could mean presenting a recommendation to the decision forum, not simply attending more meetings.

4. Where can I demonstrate that?

Identify a real assignment, decision boundaries and necessary support. Confirm what work should stop or move so the assignment is feasible.

5. Who will review it, and when?

Name the reviewer, evidence and date. Ask what remains outside this plan, including vacancies or business conditions.

Keep this to hand

My understanding is [gap], illustrated by [situation]. I will practice it through [assignment], with [support and authority]. We will review [evidence] on [date]. The remaining uncertainty is [role availability or other constraint]. Have I understood that correctly?

YOUR PRINTABLE WORKSHEET

Prepare a clearer conversation.

Use facts you can substantiate. Keep names, performance records and internal decision details private.

01 What I was told, in the words used

02 What I know / what I assumed / what I still need to ask

03 The most useful specific example to discuss

04 What evidence would demonstrate readiness?

05 A feasible assignment, authority and support needed

06 Reviewer, review date and remaining constraints

TAKE IT INTO YOUR WEEK

One useful next move.

Before you use it

Read your completed sheet once. Check each statement below.

- [ ] I have separated my contribution from the promotion decision.
- [ ] I have asked for a specific example rather than another label.
- [ ] The next assignment has realistic scope and support.
- [ ] The review date and evidence are clear to both of us.

Try it once

After the conversation, write a short factual recap and invite corrections. Review the agreed work before the next date. If expectations remain unclear, record that uncertainty rather than inventing a promise. You can then decide what to explore internally or elsewhere with better information.

Afterward, ask yourself

What became clearer? What remains unresolved? What choice does that leave me?

Work through your own situation.

If the conversation is difficult to frame, a free fit call can help you explore whether personal coaching would be useful. Bring an anonymized version of the problem.

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